initiatives for dialogue aimed at engendering peace are indeed laudable. Greater autonomy under the Constitution is also being talked about. These steps, along with relentless pressure of the security forces and waning local support, are leading to increasing frustration among the terrorists. As a result, they look for soft targets like minority community members, tourists or migrant labour to carry out acts of violence and terrorize innocents. The elected democratic government in the state is functioning with reasonable efficiency and a majority of the Kashmiris are tired of the strife and violence of the past two decades, and are yearning for peace.

As Sheikh Abdullah declared in a famous speech in June 1948, 'We the people of Jammu and Kashmir have thrown our lot with Indian people not in the heat of passion or a moment of despair, but by a deliberate choice. The union of our people has been fused by the community of ideals of common sufferings in the cause of freedom.'[6] Jammu and Kashmir is not only an integral part of our country, but it has reinforced our traditions of moderation, secularism and peaceful coexistence. It gave us the concept of Kashmiriyat, which, in essence, is the basis of our nationhood.

To achieve the goal of conflict resolution in J&K, I would like to re-emphasize the following aspects:

- Over 3000 years of history convincingly proves a shared civilization and culture between Kashmir and Hindustan. The accession of Jammu and Kashmir to India was ratified by the elected leadership of the state in 1954 during the rule of Bakshi Ghulam Mohammad, and later in 1975 under the Sheikh Abdullah accord.
- The political dialogue should now be taken forward with the participation of all segments of the people of Jammu and Kashmir. The views of people on both sides of the LoC, including the Gilgit, Skardu and Hunza areas, must also be sought. Further, the heterogeneous nature of J&K cannot be lost sight of. The composite dialogue between India and Pakistan to resolve various